SATAN'S STRATEGIES TO KEEP BELIEVERS FROM SERVING GOD

Introduction

Thomas Brooks teaches that Satan not only tempts people into open sin, but also tries to keep believers from prayer, Scripture, worship, and other spiritual duties. One of his most effective methods is making the world appear so attractive that it captures our hearts and attention.

Satan presents riches, success, comfort, possessions, entertainment, and worldly recognition in a way that makes them seem more important than God. When people become captivated by these things, they often begin neglecting spiritual disciplines. Their love for God cools, their interest in His Word weakens, and eventually some turn away from the things they once valued.

Brooks warns that more people are spiritually harmed by the world's smiles than by its hardships. Prosperity often becomes a greater snare than suffering.

Questions

1. What worldly things most compete for your attention and affection?
2. Have you ever noticed spiritual growth slowing because other interests became more important?
3. Why do you think prosperity can sometimes be more spiritually dangerous than adversity?

Remedy 1: Remember the Weakness of Worldly Things

Earthly possessions cannot protect us from disease, suffering, aging, or death. Wealth cannot guarantee health, peace, or security. Many people have had great riches and still suffered deeply.

If worldly things cannot solve life's greatest problems, they should never become our greatest priority.

Questions

1. What problems in life cannot be solved with money?
2. When have you seen wealth fail to provide security?
3. How does this help put worldly success in perspective?

Remedy 2: Remember the Vanity of Worldly Things

Solomon repeatedly declared, "Vanity of vanities; all is vanity." Worldly things promise lasting satisfaction but never deliver it. People often admit that wealth and success are fleeting, yet still devote most of their energy to pursuing them.

The heart must become convinced that earthly things are temporary and unable to satisfy the soul.

Questions

1. Why do people keep pursuing things they know will not satisfy them?
2. What pursuits in your life may be receiving too much attention?
3. How can understanding vanity help strengthen your relationship with God?

Remedy 3: Remember How Quickly Things Change

Everything in this world is uncertain. Riches, health, popularity, influence, and possessions can disappear quickly. History is filled with powerful people and kingdoms that have faded away.

Because earthly things are temporary, they should not keep us from pursuing what lasts forever.

Questions

1. What changes have you experienced that reminded you how uncertain life is?
2. How does the uncertainty of earthly things encourage dependence upon God?
3. What eternal investments should receive more of your attention?

Remedy 4: Remember That Prosperity Can Be Spiritually Dangerous

Earthly blessings often produce pride, self-confidence, distraction, and spiritual neglect. Success can gradually reduce a person's dependence upon God.

Brooks notes that worldly concerns consume enormous amounts of time, energy, and thought. The danger is not in possessions themselves, but in allowing them to rule the heart.

Questions

1. In what ways can success become a spiritual danger?
2. What activities most frequently distract you from spiritual priorities?
3. How can prosperity be enjoyed without becoming an idol?

Remedy 5: Remember That Earthly Happiness Is Always Mixed

Every earthly blessing comes with limitations. Joy is mixed with sorrow. Success is mixed with responsibility. Riches are mixed with worries. No earthly experience provides perfect satisfaction.

Only God provides unmixed and lasting joy.

Questions

1. Have you found that every earthly achievement carries new challenges?
2. Why can no earthly blessing provide perfect happiness?
3. How does this point us toward God?

Remedy 6: Become Better Acquainted With Eternal Things

One reason people become captivated by the world is that they have little appreciation for heavenly realities. Those who understand God's promises are less likely to be mastered by temporary things.

The more we treasure Christ, heaven, forgiveness, adoption, and communion with God, the less attractive worldly substitutes become.

Questions

1. What eternal truths most encourage you?
2. How does focusing on heaven affect daily priorities?
3. What spiritual blessings do you most often overlook?

Remedy 7: Remember That True Happiness Cannot Be Found in the World

No amount of money, honor, pleasure, or influence can satisfy the human soul. The world can entertain us, but it cannot give lasting peace. It cannot remove guilt, provide eternal hope, or bring us into fellowship with God.

Only Christ satisfies the deepest needs of the soul.

Questions

1. What evidence do you see that worldly success does not guarantee happiness?
2. Why do people continue chasing things that cannot satisfy?
3. How has Christ provided what the world cannot?

Remedy 8: Remember the Great Worth of Your Soul

The soul is worth far more than the whole world. Human beings were created for fellowship with God, not merely for earthly existence. To live only for worldly gain is beneath the dignity of an immortal soul.

We were created for eternal realities, union with Christ, and everlasting joy in God's presence.

Questions

1. What does the value of your soul teach you about priorities?
2. How does eternity change the way you view earthly possessions?
3. What changes might help you live more consistently with eternal values?

Lesson Summary

Brooks teaches that one of Satan's most effective devices is making the world appear more desirable than God. Wealth, comfort, success, possessions, and earthly pleasures often pull believers away from prayer, Scripture, worship, and fellowship with Christ.

The remedies are straightforward:

1. Worldly things are weak and limited.
2. Worldly things are vain and unsatisfying.
3. Worldly things are uncertain and temporary.
4. Prosperity can become spiritually dangerous.
5. Earthly happiness is always mixed with sorrow.
6. Eternal realities are far better.
7. True happiness is found only in God.
8. The soul is worth more than the whole world.

The believer overcomes this device of Satan not primarily by despising earthly things, but by seeing and embracing something better: Christ, eternal life, fellowship with God, and the promises of heaven.

Final Reflection Questions

1. Which of Brooks' eight remedies spoke most strongly to you?
2. What worldly pursuit currently competes most with your devotion to Christ?
3. How can you intentionally place eternal priorities above temporary concerns this week?
4. What practical steps can help you pursue God more faithfully in prayer, Scripture, and worship?
5. If someone watched your life for one week, what would they conclude is your greatest treasure?